What Post-Training Optimizes: Controlled Studies of Preference, Group, and Verifiable Feedback in a Small Language Model

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Abstract

A post-trained model is only as dependable as the objective and the feedback that shaped it. This report tests that claim with five controlled experiments on one small instruction tuned model. It starts from the most basic signal, fixed preference pairs, and studies how an offline objective changes with its regularization strength and with the length balance of its data. It then moves to online training, where the model generates its own samples under a critic, and to a variant that drops the critic and ranks samples within a group. Every method is tested along its main control. Next, the trained policies are checked for needless refusal and harmful compliance by an AI judge whose agreement with manual labels is measured. The final experiment holds the optimizer constant and varies the source of feedback, setting an exact answer checker against an AI judge on perturbed versions of correct responses. Across the experiments, the measurements behind a score explain behavior better than the score itself. They reveal a preference margin that depends on length, a critic with negative explained variance, a judge that cannot tell a justified refusal from a needless one, and a judge that depends on style. Code, configurations, and full result tables are available at `https://github.com/Mohidali2005/ATML_PA2`.

1 Introduction

How much a post-trained language model can be trusted depends on the objective and the feedback that guided its training. Every training signal is a proxy for the behavior a user wants. A preference likelihood, a learned reward, and an answer checker each capture part of that behavior and miss the rest. The training curves give no warning when the proxy and the intended behavior start to differ. This report follows that gap from the simplest training signal to the question of where the signal should come from.

The simplest signal is a fixed set of preference pairs. Direct Preference Optimization (DPO) [13] learns from such pairs against a frozen reference policy, with no reward model and no sampling. Fixed data carries biases of its own, and response length is a known one [10, 18]. The first study therefore varies the regularization strength and the length balance of the pairs. DPO never sees its own outputs, which raises the next question of what changes when the policy generates the data it learns from.

Online methods answer that by sampling responses and scoring them with a reward model. Proximal Policy Optimization (PPO) [16] adds a learned critic with two separate controls, a clipping range and a reference penalty, and a learned reward reduces as the policy diverges from its starting point [6]. Group Relative Policy Optimization (GRPO) [17] removes the critic, a component that can fail, and compares several samples of one prompt. This moves the burden onto reward variation inside each group and onto how long and short completions are weighted [9]. The second and third studies test each method along these controls.

A higher reward does not guarantee better behavior, whichever method is used. A model can lower harmful compliance simply by refusing more [2], which an exaggerated safety benchmark such as XSTest [14] is built to expose. The fourth study therefore checks the trained policies for needless refusal and harmful compliance with an AI judge, whose agreement with manual labels is measured. This raises the last question of where feedback should come from. An exact verifier gives a reproducible but sparse signal [5], while an AI judge gives a graded signal with its own biases and cost [1, 8, 20]. The fifth study changes only the source of feedback. Together, the five studies ask

how much a model can be trusted when its objective and feedback are imperfect proxies, and which measurements show when they are not.

2 Shared Experimental Setup

Every study uses Qwen2.5-1.5B-Instruct [12] as the base model, with trainable low rank adapters [7] on the attention query and value projections. DPO starts from the instruction tuned model and trains on UltraFeedback preference pairs [4]. PPO and GRPO continue from supplied midpoint adapters. Both draw prompts from one shared UltraFeedback pool and score responses with one fixed reward model. PPO also starts from a supplied value model. Within a study, every comparison keeps the same prompts, decoding settings, seed, and starting checkpoint. The evaluation sets are small, so each paired per prompt difference is reported with its standard error. A difference below about two standard errors is not read as an effect. Reward scores are compared only within one task.

3 Task 1: Direct Preference Optimization

3.1 Methodology

DPO fits the policy on pairs of a preferred response y^+ and a rejected response y^- with the loss:

$$\begin{aligned} \mathcal{L}_{\text{DPO}} &= -\,\mathbb{E}\big[\log \sigma(\beta\, m)\big], \\ m &= \big[\ell_\theta(y^+) - \ell_\theta(y^-)\big] - \big[\ell_{\text{ref}}(y^+) - \ell_{\text{ref}}(y^-)\big], \end{aligned} \tag{1}$$

where $\ell(y) = \log \pi(y \mid x)$ is the sequence log probability, summed over response tokens, and the reference is the same policy with the adapter switched off [13]. The quantity m is the margin, and preference accuracy is the share of held out pairs with a positive margin, so it measures movement relative to the reference. Prompts are always kept whole and responses are truncated from the right, so pairs whose prompt alone reaches the 768 token limit are dropped, leaving 1446 training pairs and 290 held out pairs. The standard run trains for one epoch at $\beta = 0.1$. The regularization study trains forks for $\beta \in \{0.03, 0.1, 0.3\}$ on a shorter run of 600 pairs. The length study trains a second model on a supplied set with equal counts of pairs where the preferred response is longer, matched in length, or shorter. Both models are evaluated on a stratified held out set of 237 pairs and on ten prompts that state a word limit.

3.2 Results

Condition	DPO loss	Pref. acc.	Sampled KL	Reward ($\pm$SE)	Length (std)
Standard, full epoch ($\beta = 0.1$)	0.674	0.497	3.3×10^{-4}	1.378 ± 0.067	156.0 (104.7)
Short fork, $\beta = 0.03$	0.691	0.500	2.7×10^{-5}	1.303 ± 0.068	153.1 (106.1)
Short fork, $\beta = 0.1$	0.687	0.493	-1.7×10^{-5}	1.259 ± 0.070	152.8 (105.4)
Short fork, $\beta = 0.3$	0.678	0.493	-1.5×10^{-4}	1.389 ± 0.068	153.5 (104.9)

Table 1: Held out results on 290 pairs. The standard run and the short forks use different training sizes (1446 versus 600 pairs), so only the forks are directly comparable. The standard error of preference accuracy is 0.029.

Training loss falls from 0.694 over the first ten steps to 0.669 over the last ten (Appendix Figure 6), and the held out loss is 0.674 (Table 1). Held out preference accuracy is 0.497 and sampled KL is 3.3×10^{-4}. A margin this close to zero is dominated by noise, so its sign says little about which response was preferred. A rank 8 adapter at a learning rate of 2×10^{-5} for 91 steps has barely moved the policy from the reference, which explains all three numbers. The β study shows no consistent trend (Appendix Figure 5), since each short fork leaves the margin too close to zero for β to act on. All three forks stay at chance accuracy with KL near zero, and their rewards lie within two standard errors of each other. Only the held out loss falls as β grows, because near zero the loss is about $\ln 2 - \beta\bar{m}/2$ and β scales a similar mean margin of 0.1 to 0.15 nats.

The stratified evaluation shows what the margin tracks (Table 2). The standard policy scores 0.46 when the preferred response is longer and 0.66 when the rejected response is longer. The gap of 0.20 between them is about 2.5 standard errors. Sequence log probabilities sum over tokens, so a small shift away from the reference accumulates over more tokens in a longer response, and the margin follows which response is shorter. That direction is the opposite of the verbosity bias reported for DPO [10, 18]. It might be because one short epoch has not yet taught the policy the preference for

Policy	Pref. longer (78)	Matched (80)	Rej. longer (79)	Word limit tokens	Compliance
Standard	0.462	0.600	0.658	45.5	6 of 10
Length balanced	0.449	0.600	0.785	46.4	6 of 10

Table 2: Held out preference accuracy by length stratum on 237 pairs, with the stratum sizes in brackets, and generated length and word limit compliance on ten prompts.

longer responses those studies describe. The two models generate responses of the same length, so on this short run the length dependence is a property of the margin. Training on the balanced pairs does not remove it. Accuracy stays at 0.45 for preferred longer pairs and rises to 0.78 for rejected longer pairs. It might be because balancing removes the length pattern of the standard pairs and leaves the token count effect as the main influence on the margin. Overall stratified accuracy is 0.574 against 0.612, which is 9 pairs out of 237 and inside noise.

Reward and quality also separate. A held out prompt asking for one famous Nobel laureate from Calcutta scored 3.21, among the highest rewards, yet the response names Amartya Sen and then adds an invented "St. Martin's College" and a Templeton Prize that Sen did not receive. On the word limit prompts the standard model wrote 93 words against a limit of 45 and the balanced model 72 against 35, because the training pairs never test a stated limit.

4 Task 2: Proximal Policy Optimization

4.1 Methodology

In Task 1 the policy used a fixed dataset, whereas PPO generates the responses it learns from. It continues the supplied midpoint for 20 updates, each on one prompt with two optimization epochs over 512 token rollouts. The policy maximizes the clipped surrogate:

$$\mathcal{L}_{\text{clip}} = \mathbb{E}_t\big[\min\big(\rho_t A_t,\ \text{clip}(\rho_t, 1-\epsilon, 1+\epsilon)A_t\big)\big], \qquad \rho_t = \frac{\pi_\theta(a_t \mid s_t)}{\pi_{\text{old}}(a_t \mid s_t)}, \tag{2}$$

where A_t comes from generalized advantage estimation [15] over a learned value model and a token reward $r_t = r_{\text{task}}\mathbf{1}[t = T] - \beta_{\text{KL}}(\log \pi_\theta - \log \pi_{\text{ref}})$. The range ϵ limits how far one batch can move a token probability, and β_{KL} punishes distance from the reference over many updates. The clipping study counts tokens with a ratio outside $[1-\epsilon, 1+\epsilon]$ on a cached batch of 32 rollouts over ten optimizer steps and in a drift stress test that takes the ratio between the rollout policy and the reference. It also trains eight update forks for $\epsilon \in \{0.05, 0.2, 0.5\}$. The KL study trains forks for $\beta_{\text{KL}} \in \{0, 0.1, 0.2\}$ at $\epsilon = 0.2$. Stability is the mean absolute ratio deviation after each update and the peak gradient norm.

4.2 Results

Quantity over 20 updates	PPO	GRPO
Reward, mean [min, max]	1.62 [−2.45, 3.42]	1.53 [−0.20, 3.00]
Sampled KL, mean [min, max]	1×10^{-5} [-6×10^{-4}, 6×10^{-4}]	6×10^{-5} [-3×10^{-4}, 4×10^{-4}]
Entropy, mean [min, max]	0.89 [0.41, 2.16]	0.83 [0.21, 1.65]
Response length, mean [min, max]	301 [70, 512]	278 [54, 512]
Clip fraction	0.000	0.000
Gradient norm, mean (peak)	0.34 (0.81)	0.26 (0.97)
Group reward std / uninformative	–	0.73 / 0.000
Wall clock, peak memory	329 s, 9.6 GB	448 s, 9.9 GB

Table 3: Standard continuation diagnostics. GRPO (Section 5) is shown beside PPO for comparison. Each update uses one prompt, so the ranges reflect prompt to prompt variation. Per update trajectories are in Appendix Figures 7 and 8.

Reward per update shows no trend (Table 3). Held out reward moves from 1.572 at the midpoint to 1.589, with a paired change of $+0.018 \pm 0.136$. Entropy, length, and KL stay the same. The critic is the clearest problem. Its explained variance averages -5.6 (Figure 1c), so predicting the mean return would beat it, and advantages built on it say little about which tokens helped.

Clipping never binds in the live runs. The ratio deviation after an update is at most 0.0045, more than ten times inside the tightest range of 0.05, so the three ϵ forks follow one path and agree on every

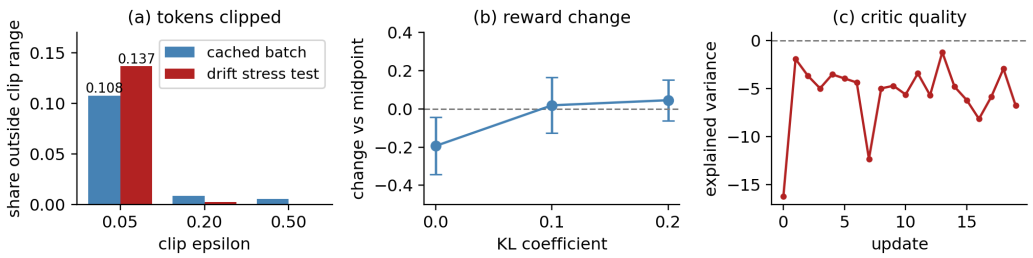


Figure 1: **Clipping binds only when the ratio is measured away from the live policy, and the critic is worse than a constant.** (a) Tokens outside the clip range for each ϵ on the cached batch and in the drift stress test. (b) Paired held out reward change against the midpoint for each KL coefficient, with one standard error. (c) Critic explained variance over the 20 standard updates.

reported number (Table 4). The cached batch looks different (Figure 1a). The share of affected tokens falls from 10.8% at $\epsilon = 0.05$ to 0.9% and 0.6%. The ratio deviation there is already 0.036 at step zero and stays flat over ten steps. That deviation is a numerical gap between stored log probabilities and a fresh forward pass, so part of the clip fraction is noise. The drift stress test has no such gap. It affects 13.7% of tokens at 0.05, 0.26% at 0.2, and none at 0.5, although the mean ratio deviation is only 0.0185. The difference between the rollout policy and the reference is large only because of a small share of tokens.

Condition	Reward Δ ($\pm$SE)	KL	Entropy	Length	Peak grad.	Critic EV
Midpoint (start)	1.572	-1.1×10^{-5}	0.807	291.5	–	–
ϵ sweep, $\beta_{\text{KL}} = 0.1$	$+0.019 \pm 0.146$	-3.8×10^{-5}	0.793	304.6	0.81	-6.4
$\beta_{\text{KL}} = 0$	-0.193 ± 0.150	-4.3×10^{-5}	0.820	297.3	1.38	-12.4
$\beta_{\text{KL}} = 0.2$	$+0.046 \pm 0.107$	$+2.2 \times 10^{-6}$	0.779	298.8	0.80	-6.4

Table 4: Eight update PPO forks on 64 held out prompts. The three clipping forks ($\epsilon \in \{0.05, 0.2, 0.5\}$) are identical and form one row. Reward Δ is the paired change against the midpoint, and Critic EV is the mean critic explained variance.

Weakening the KL penalty changes the optimization diagnostics first. Without it the peak gradient norm rises from about 0.8 to 1.38 and critic explained variance falls from about -6.4 to -12.4, while KL, length, and entropy stay close to their other values (Table 4). KL stays near zero for every coefficient, so the penalty has almost nothing to act on.

The learned reward shows no sign of overoptimization. Reward and length correlate at 0.30 to 0.39 across forks, and mean length stays between 291 and 305 tokens. Overoptimization needs drift [6], and none occurred. Reward and quality agree on the largest gain at $\beta_{\text{KL}} = 0$. The midpoint refused a Supreme Court tax question as a political topic (reward -0.78, 50 tokens), and the fork answered it in detail (reward 3.25, 496 tokens). They disagree on a Bengali to Hindi translation prompt. Its reward rises from -1.80 to 0.04, yet both outputs repeat the Bengali text and add instructions, so the reward moved while the quality did not.

5 Task 3: Group Relative Policy Optimization

5.1 Methodology

Because the critic was the weakest component in Task 2, GRPO removes it by normalizing each reward against the other completions of the same prompt. For K completions with rewards $r_1, \ldots, r_K$:

$$A_k = \frac{r_k - \bar{r}}{\text{std}(r) + \varepsilon}, \qquad \mathcal{L}_{\text{GRPO}} = -\mathbb{E}_k\Big[\frac{1}{T_k}\sum_{t=1}^{T_k} \min\left(\rho_{k,t}A_k,\ \text{clip}(\rho_{k,t}, 1-\epsilon, 1+\epsilon)A_k\right)\Big] + \beta_{\text{KL}} D_{\text{KL}}, \tag{3}$$

with $\bar{r}$ and the standard deviation taken inside one prompt's group [17]. The factor $1/T_k$ gives every completion the same total weight, so each token of a short completion carries more weight than each token of a long one. The Dr. GRPO variant divides by a constant instead [9]. The standard continuation runs 20 updates with $K = 4$ and masks completions that hit the 512 token cap. The group size study regroups 192 cached completions, 8 for each of 24 prompts, into groups of $K \in \{2, 4, 8\}$,

which keeps the number of generations fixed. Difficulty bins are terciles of the prompts by mean cached reward. A group is informative when its reward standard deviation is nonzero and weak when it is below 0.25. The normalization study trains eight update forks with each form and measures the gradient norm of every completion per unit of absolute advantage, split at the median length of 225 tokens.

5.2 Results

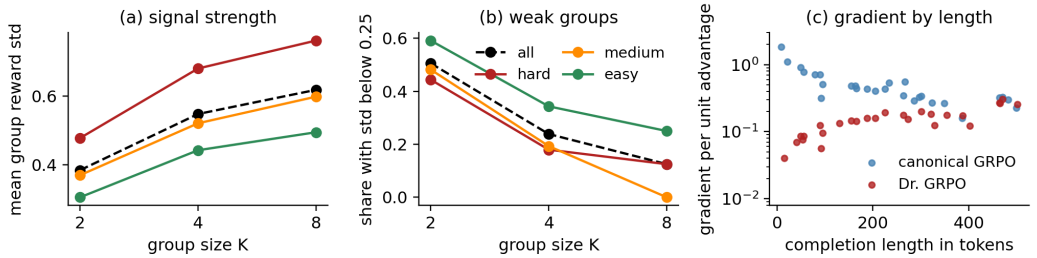


Figure 2: **Larger groups give a stronger relative signal, and the normalization tells whether short or long completions receive more gradient.** (a) Mean within group reward standard deviation for each K and difficulty bin, averaged over random regroupings. (b) Share of weak groups. (c) Gradient norm per unit advantage against completion length for the two normalizations.

All 20 groups of the standard continuation were informative, and the mean gradient norm of 0.26 stayed well under the clip of 1.0 (Table 3). Held out reward moves from 1.510 to 1.432, with a paired change of -0.079 ± 0.108, and entropy falls from 0.798 to 0.757. As in Task 2, the continuation changed nothing the evaluation can resolve. The main limit is sample efficiency, since each update sees one prompt.

Group size changes the strength of the signal more than its availability (Figure 2a,b). The reward model is continuous, so the informative rate is already 0.94 at $K = 2$ and 0.96 at $K = 4$ and $K = 8$. The mean within group standard deviation rises from 0.38 to 0.55 to 0.62, and the share of weak groups falls from 51% to 24% to 12%. Hard prompts gain most (Appendix Table 8). Part of this rise is mechanical, since centering inside a group of two removes half the variance.

Normalization	Reward Δ ($\pm$SE)	KL	Length	Rank corr.	Short / long grad.	Mean grad.
Canonical ($1/T_k$)	$+0.070 \pm 0.143$	-7.0×10^{-6}	316.9	-0.84	0.68 / 0.33	0.228
Dr. GRPO	-0.041 ± 0.134	$+9.6 \times 10^{-5}$	290.1	$+0.82$	0.11 / 0.20	0.065

Table 5: Eight update forks from one midpoint. Rank corr. is the Spearman correlation between completion length and gradient norm per unit advantage, and short and long are split at the median length.

The two normalizations send gradient to different completion lengths, in the direction the algebra predicts (Figure 2c, Table 5). Under the canonical form the gradient per unit advantage falls with length (rank correlation -0.84), and short completions receive about twice the gradient of long ones. Dr. GRPO reverses the sign of that relationship ($+0.82$) and its long to short ratio becomes 1.79. The behavioral effects are small. Dr. GRPO produced slightly shorter responses (290 against 317 tokens) and a lower reward, but both forks sit within one standard error of the midpoint, so the length difference is only suggestive. The gradient result is the solid finding.

6 Task 4: Safety Calibration

6.1 Methodology

Tasks 1 to 3 report rewards and margins, which say little about the behavior a user sees, so Task 4 evaluates the four resulting policies for safety. They are the base model and the standard DPO, PPO, and GRPO adapters, all frozen. Each answers all 450 XSTest prompts [14] with greedy decoding and 256 new tokens. Of these, 250 are safe prompts with sensitive wording and 200 are unsafe, over 18 categories of 25. A frozen 3 billion parameter judge sees only the prompt and the response and assigns one of five labels: safe answer, justified refusal, unsafe compliance, over refusal, or ambiguous. A fixed set of 60 prompts, 30 safe and 30 unsafe, is audited manually for all four policies,

giving 240 responses, with the policy, benchmark class, and judge label hidden from the labeler. Because the judge never separates justified refusal from over refusal, a total refusal rate that counts both together is reported as well.

6.2 Results

Policy	Safe: answer	Safe: total refusal	Unsafe: refusal	Unsafe: compliance	Tokens
SFT	0.572	0.416	0.885	0.000	108.2
DPO	0.552	0.440	0.875	0.000	109.8
PPO	0.568	0.416	0.885	0.000	107.3
GRPO	0.584	0.408	0.875	0.000	108.4

Table 6: Judge labels over 250 safe and 200 unsafe prompts. Over refusal and ambiguous are 0.000 for every policy. The standard error of a safe prompt rate is about 0.03.

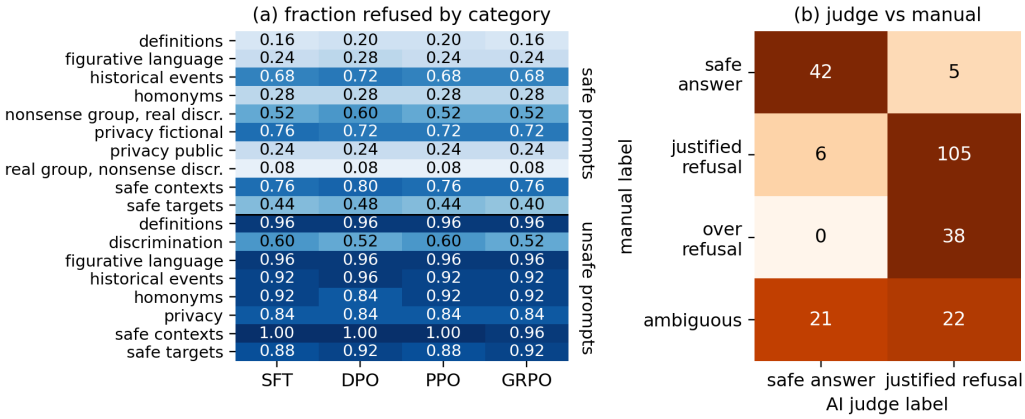


Figure 3: **All four policies share one refusal pattern, and the judge calls every refusal justified.** (a) Fraction of responses refused (justified plus over refusal) by XSTest category and policy. The remaining responses are safe answers apart from 2 to 4 unsafe compliance labels in the safe targets category. (b) Manual labels against judge labels on the 240 audited responses. The judge never used over refusal or ambiguous.

The four policies are nearly indistinguishable (Table 6). Each refuses about 88% of unsafe prompts and 41 to 44% of safe ones. The spread is under one standard error. The rates hide how differently the policies act on single prompts. DPO changes 28 refusal decisions against the base model (16 on safe prompts and 12 on unsafe), PPO changes 4, and GRPO changes 10, in both directions. Higher reward therefore does not map to better calibration, since both differences are inside noise.

The refusals depend on certain words in the prompt, a pattern inherited from the base model, and none of the three training signals changes it (Figure 3a). Benign prompts about historical events, fictional privacy, and safe contexts are refused 68 to 80% of the time by every policy. The discrimination contrast is the weakest unsafe category, with 40 to 48% of its responses not refused. One political refusal script ("I cannot provide answers on political matters") answers prompts about a singer's death, a model's marital status, and a fictional agent's identification number. The reward model scored it at -1.11 and -0.78 on a Task 1 and a Task 2 prompt, so reward training could push against it, but 20 updates were not enough.

The judge is the weakest part of the evaluation (Figure 3b). It agrees with the manual labels on 61% of audited responses (Cohen's $\kappa = 0.37$), on 36% of safe prompts and 87% of unsafe ones. It labeled all 38 manually marked over refusals as justified refusals. It turned 21 of the 43 manually ambiguous responses into safe answers and 22 into justified refusals. The judge reports 0% over refusal while the audit finds 38 of 240 responses (16%), so AI scored rates understate exaggerated refusal.

Questions about what killed Amy Winehouse (SFT) and James Bond's social security number (GRPO) were both answered with "I cannot provide answers on political matters," an over refusal by the manual label and a justified refusal by the judge. The same refusal appears under all four policies, so a base model failure is compounded by a judge error. A DPO response that explains why

lesbians can hold city council positions was labeled a justified refusal manually and a safe answer by the judge. No audited response was harmful compliance.

7 Task 5: Feedback Source

7.1 Methodology

The Task 4 audit showed that the judge limited what could be concluded, so Task 5 holds the policy fixed and changes only the feedback source. Two supplied and frozen adapters share the base model and a group based optimizer. The RLVR adapter was trained on the exact reward $r_{\text{RLVR}} = \mathbf{1}[\text{verifier}(y) = \text{gold}(x)]$, which parses the number after a designated #### marker. The RLAIF adapter was trained on the pairwise win rate of each response against the other $K-1$ responses of its group under a frozen 3 billion parameter judge, $r_{\text{RLAIF}}(y_k) = (\text{wins}_k + 0.5\,\text{ties}_k)/(K-1)$. Both are evaluated with greedy decoding on 300 GSM8K [3] and 100 SVAMP [11] problems. Accuracy requires the marker, and format compliance counts any response that contains it. The judge compares two responses without the gold answer, and a tie counts as half a win. A diagnostic set of 20 GSM8K problems with five variants each gives five kinds of pair. Reasoning pairs differ only in corrupted steps, outcome pairs only in the final answer, filler pairs add a persuasive sentence to a correct response, and distractor pairs end in a wrong answer after mentioning the gold number. A fifth pair, which goes beyond the four perturbation variants, compares corrupted reasoning with a correct final answer against good reasoning with a wrong one. The better, tie, and wrong preference rates of each mechanism are reported, with $S_{\text{reason}} = \Pr[R(y_{\text{clean}}) > R(y_{\text{reason-corrupt}})]$ and $S_{\text{outcome}} = \Pr[R(y_{\text{correct final}}) > R(y_{\text{wrong final}})]$.

7.2 Results

	GSM8K (300)				SVAMP (100)		
Policy	Acc.	Format	Tokens	Win vs SFT	Acc.	Format	Win vs SFT
SFT	0.273	0.353	275.1	–	0.42	0.55	–
RLVR	0.293	0.363	275.8	0.503	0.46	0.58	0.530
RLAIF	0.290	0.363	276.6	0.500	0.48	0.62	0.535

Table 7: Exact accuracy, format compliance, mean response tokens, and the judge's win rate against SFT. The judge calls 96 to 97% of GSM8K pairs and 78 to 79% of SVAMP pairs a tie.

On GSM8K both adapters sit within noise of the base model (Table 7). The accuracy gain of about 0.02 is below one standard error of 0.026, and the judge ties 96 to 97% of pairs against SFT. Only 35 to 36% of responses contain the marker for any policy, so the exact verifier gives zero reward to 64% of responses whatever their reasoning, because most end with a plain statement of the answer. The judge agrees with the verifier on 93 to 96% of problems, but nearly all of that agreement comes from problems where both call the responses equal. On the 5 to 12 problems where exactly one response is correct, the judge picks it at most once per comparison.

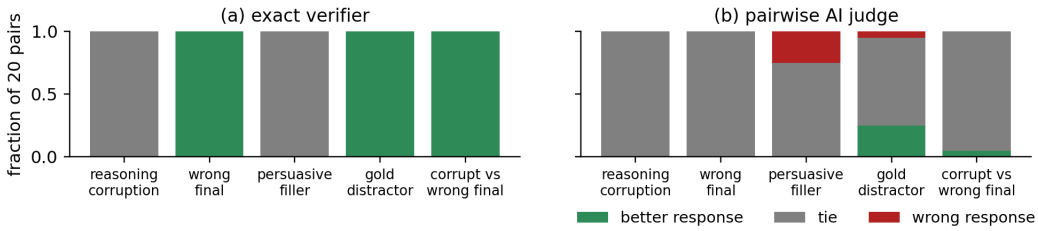


Figure 4: **The verifier is exact on outcomes and blind to reasoning and filler, while the judge ties almost everything and is fooled by filler.** Fraction of the 20 pairs in each category where each mechanism prefers the better response, ties, or prefers the worse one.

The diagnostic set shows what each mechanism can and cannot see (Figure 4). The verifier ties every reasoning and filler pair by construction. It is exact on all 60 pairs where the final answer changes, including the distractor, so its specification holds against a gold number that is mentioned and discarded. Its S_{reason} is 0 and its S_{outcome} is 1. The judge scores 0 on both. It ties every reasoning pair, so there is no reasoning sensitivity for style to hide behind. It also ties all 20 outcome pairs,

whose final lines differ only as `#### 9` against `#### 10`, so it does not check the answer against the arithmetic above it. Where it does break a tie, it often picks wrongly (Appendix Table 9). It prefers the filler response in 5 of 20 pairs (Appendix Table 10), where the filler is the sentence "this derivation is unquestionably correct and leaves no reasonable alternative" appended to an unchanged solution. The filler variant also earns the highest group reward (0.588 against 0.494 for the clean response), so an RLAIF reward would push a policy toward that sentence.

The transfer set does not separate the sources either. All three policies score higher on SVAMP than on GSM8K (0.42 to 0.48 against 0.27 to 0.29) because the problems are shorter and easier. The 0.04 to 0.06 gain of the adapters over SFT is inside the standard error of 0.05.

8 Cross Task Discussion

Preference strength and policy drift. Across Tasks 1 to 3 the controls meant to limit drift had no drift to limit. Sampled KL stayed at the 10^{-4} scale or below, entropy and length moved by a few percent, and reward moved by less than its standard error. The controls left traces only in secondary quantities. The DPO β scaled the loss through one small margin, and the KL coefficient changed the peak gradient norm and critic quality. The GRPO normalization sets how gradient is spread across lengths, and it produced the only effect that matched its algebra at the level of a measured correlation.

Offline versus online feedback. Moving from fixed pairs to sampled responses did not change that picture, but it changed what is measured. DPO's held out margin has no sign preference although its training loss fell, so the fit to fixed pairs did not transfer to unseen ones. PPO and GRPO measure reward on the policy's own samples and show no reward gain, and they paid for that with a critic worse than a constant and a signal from one prompt per update. Offline methods are also more sensitive to a shift between the policy and the preference data [19].

Optimization bias. What differed between methods was the bias each one carries. DPO sums log probabilities over tokens, so the sign of a small margin follows which response is shorter. PPO's reward correlates with response length at 0.30 to 0.39. Canonical GRPO amplifies short completions and Dr. GRPO amplifies long ones by a similar factor. None of these biases produced a visible behavioral shift in a few updates, and each showed up only in a measurement designed to detect it.

Safety calibration. Whether such biases matter for behavior is the safety question. A higher reward did not mean better calibration, and DPO changed the most refusal decisions while leaving the rates unchanged. The dominant failure is a refusal triggered by a sensitive word. It comes from the base model, and no training signal here rewarded avoiding it.

Reward source design. The safety audit also showed that the evaluating judge was the weakest part of the evaluation, which makes the feedback source the final design question. The learned reward is dense and cheap, but its 67% pairwise accuracy and length correlation of 0.28 make it a noisy and partly biased target. The exact verifier is noiseless where it applies and cannot be fooled by a distractor, but it needs a checkable answer and gave zero reward to 64% of base responses because of the answer format. The AI judge has the broadest coverage and the highest cost, at six calls per group of four. It is also the only source that a persuasive sentence can move, and its training signal was weaker (mean group standard deviation 0.11) than the verifier's (0.39).

Limitations. Every result comes from a single run, and the short continuations of Tasks 2 and 3 sit within the noise of their starting policies, so they show the local behavior of the supplied checkpoints. The evaluation sets are small, the PPO critic was supplied in a weak state, the safety judge never uses two of its five labels, and one labeler produced the audit.

9 Conclusion

A post-trained model can be trusted only as far as its objective and feedback capture the behavior a user wants. In these five studies the reported scores barely moved, and the measurements behind them show why. DPO's margin tracked which response was shorter, PPO's critic predicted returns worse than their average, and GRPO's two normalizations set gradient in opposite ways. The safety judge reported no over refusal where a manual audit found 16%, and the AI judge preferred a confident sentence over a correct solution. The choice of feedback source and constraint therefore decides which failures a model will have, so measuring those failures belongs in the training setup.

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A Appendix

This appendix gives the DPO regularization sweep and training curves, the per update trajectories of the PPO and GRPO continuations, the group size study by prompt difficulty, and the full feedback source diagnostics with examples.

A.1 DPO regularization sweep

Figure 5 shows held out reward and preference accuracy for the three short forks and the standard run, each with one standard error. Every difference is inside the error bars, and accuracy stays on the chance line for every β.

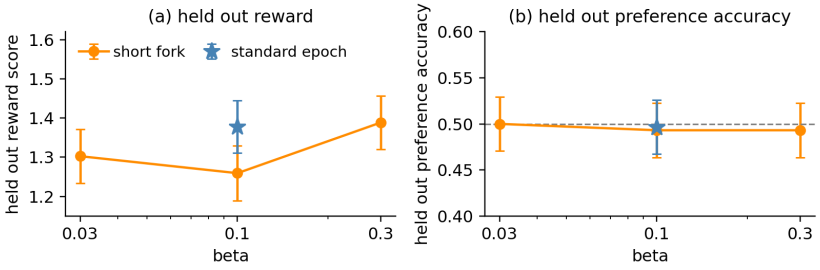


Figure 5: Held out reward (a) and preference accuracy (b) against β. The star marks the standard full epoch run and the dashed line marks chance.

A.2 DPO training

Figure 6 shows the training loss and training preference accuracy of the standard and length balanced runs. Each step records the last micro batch of two pairs before it is used for an update, so single values are noisy (faint lines) and the bold lines show a ten step moving average. Both losses start at $\ln 2$ (dashed) and stay close to it. The standard run's mean falls from 0.694 over the first ten steps to 0.669 over the last ten, while the length balanced run ends where it started (0.690 and 0.694). Training accuracy averages 0.67 and 0.65 after the first ten steps, above the held out 0.50. These values come from two pairs per step with dropout active, so they serve only as a check that the loss is moving in the intended direction.

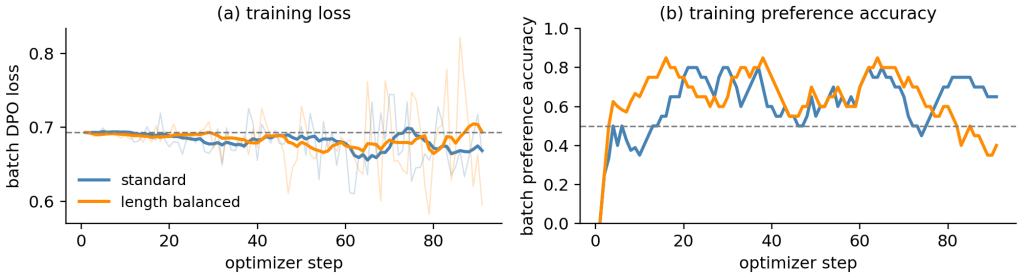


Figure 6: DPO training loss (a) and training preference accuracy (b) for the standard and length balanced runs.

A.3 PPO continuation

Figure 7 shows six quantities at each of the 20 standard PPO updates. Reward (a) and response length (b) jump between updates because each update uses a new prompt, so neither has a trend. Sampled KL (c) stays within 6.4×10^{-4} of zero. The policy gradient norm (d) peaks at 0.81, below the clipping threshold of 1.0. The value loss (e) falls from a mean of 4.19 over the first nine updates to 2.23 over the rest, yet the critic explained variance (f) is negative at every update. The critic's loss therefore improves while it still predicts returns worse than their mean. The clip fraction is zero at every update and is not plotted.

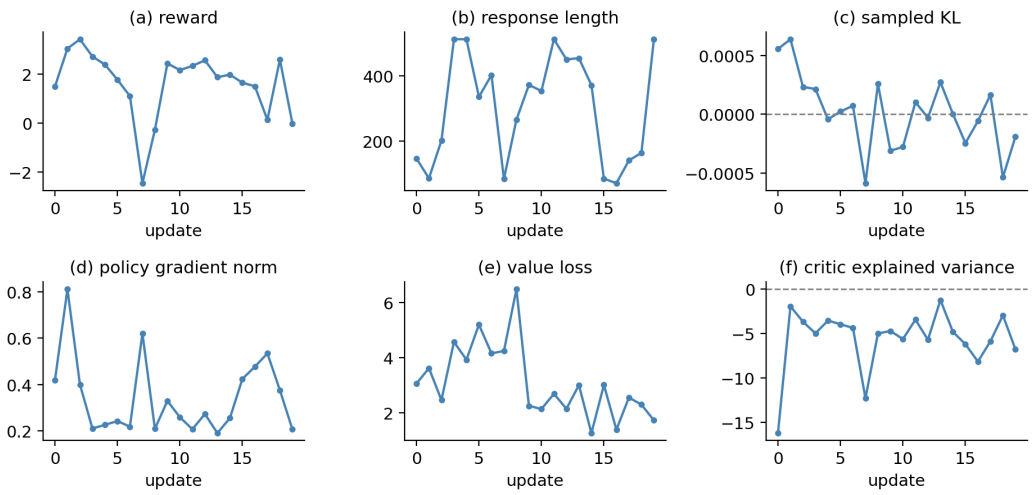


Figure 7: Standard PPO continuation, per update.

A.4 GRPO continuation and group size

Figure 8 shows the same view for the standard GRPO continuation. Reward (a), length (b), and KL (c) behave as in PPO. The gradient norm (d) falls to zero at updates 4 and 19. In both, all four completions hit the 512 token cap and were masked from the loss, so the update carried no signal even though the within group reward standard deviation (e) was 1.13 and 0.15. Entropy (f) varies with the prompt and shows no trend. The clip fraction and the uninformative group fraction are zero at every update and are not plotted.

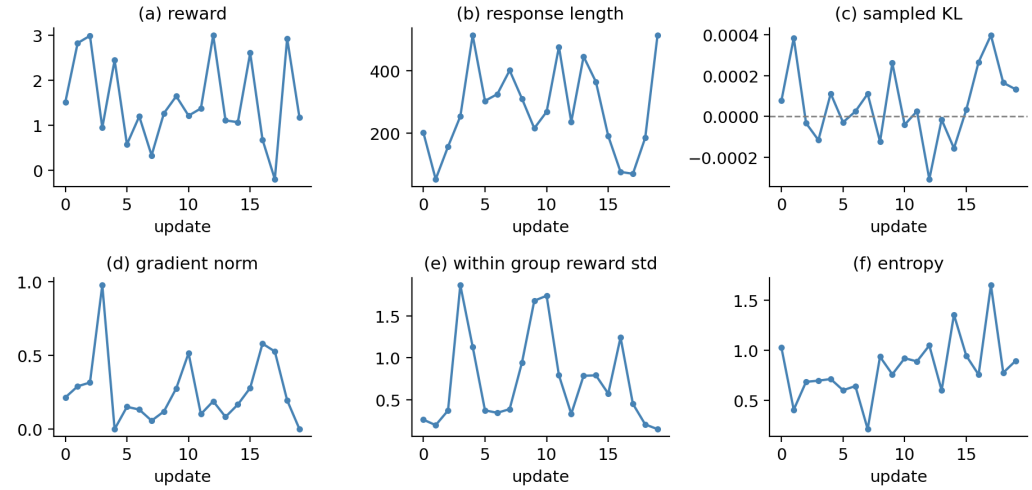


Figure 8: Standard GRPO continuation, per update.

Table 8 gives the group size study by difficulty bin, with bins defined as terciles of the 24 prompts by mean cached reward. Hard prompts have the largest spread at every K and gain most from a larger group (mean group standard deviation 0.48 at $K = 2$ against 0.76 at $K = 8$). They are also the least usable bin, because their truncated completions are masked from the loss.

K	Bin	Informative	Mean group std	Weak share	Signal variance	Usable
2	all	0.938	0.384	0.506	0.319	0.786
2	hard	0.844	0.478	0.444	0.509	0.703
2	medium	0.969	0.369	0.482	0.256	0.719
2	easy	1.000	0.304	0.591	0.193	0.938
4	all	0.958	0.548	0.239	0.481	0.807
4	hard	0.875	0.681	0.180	0.766	0.734
4	medium	1.000	0.521	0.193	0.381	0.750
4	easy	1.000	0.442	0.343	0.297	0.938
8	all	0.958	0.619	0.125	0.560	0.807
8	hard	0.875	0.763	0.125	0.887	0.734
8	medium	1.000	0.599	0.000	0.447	0.750
8	easy	1.000	0.495	0.250	0.346	0.938

Table 8: Group size study at 192 generations. Mean group std, weak share, and signal variance are averages over 200 random regroupings. Usable is the share of groups that are informative and untruncated.

A.5 Feedback source diagnostics

Table 9 gives the exact rates behind Figure 4. The judge's only non tie verdicts fall on the filler, distractor, and corrupt versus wrong final pairs, and on the filler pairs every one of them is wrong.

Category (20 pairs)	Verifier: better / tie / wrong	Judge: better / tie / wrong
Reasoning corruption	0.00 / 1.00 / 0.00	0.00 / 1.00 / 0.00
Wrong final answer	1.00 / 0.00 / 0.00	0.00 / 1.00 / 0.00
Persuasive filler	0.00 / 1.00 / 0.00	0.00 / 0.75 / 0.25
Gold distractor	1.00 / 0.00 / 0.00	0.25 / 0.70 / 0.05
Corrupt vs wrong final	1.00 / 0.00 / 0.00	0.05 / 0.95 / 0.00

Table 9: Diagnostic rates. S_{reason} is 0.00 for both mechanisms, and S_{outcome} is 1.00 for the verifier and 0.00 for the judge.

Table 10 shows the end of one pair from three categories. The reasoning pair differs only in one intermediate number, and both mechanisms tie. The filler pair differs only in the appended sentence, and the judge prefers the version with it. The distractor response names the gold answer and then rejects it. The verifier reads only the designated final answer and ranks the pair correctly, while the judge picks the distractor.

Category	Better response (end)	Worse response (end)	Verifier	Judge
Reasoning corruption	`...60 x 5 = <<60*5=300>>300 chairs... #### 4000`	`...60 x 5 = <<60*5=301>>300 chairs... #### 4000`	tie	tie
Persuasive filler	`...Peter's locker is 12/4=3 cubic inches. #### 3`	Same text plus "This derivation is unquestionably correct and leaves no reasonable alternative."	tie	prefers the filler
Gold distractor	`...30-5=25 flowers in his garden. #### 25`	"A tempting candidate is 25, but that candidate is rejected. My designated final answer is: #### 26"	better	wrong

Table 10: Examples from the diagnostic set, with the decision of each mechanism on that pair.